a very close relationship with the Northern Alliance, and we naturally wanted to build on that'.[109] He even denies that there was any disagreement in the bureaucratic and security echelons regarding an UF-centric approach after the Bonn conference. This was because India 'should have an interest in supporting such groups who are only taking on the Taliban and the Pakistani ISI'.[110] X, who was part of the government until relatively recently was 'disappointed' by the Manmohan Singh government for not cultivating strong links with 'our friends from the North and focusing simply on the Kabul government, or, more so, with the Pashtuns.'[111] He blames that as the key reason for India's lack of influence in Afghanistan today. 'We are unable to keep the north together politically, leave militarily. There is infighting among former United Front guys. That's bad. Also, we don't have the capital or ability to help the Pashtuns in south as much. Kandahar is important, but Pakistan has more reach there. Despite what Shivshankar Menon says, we have lost both north and south', argues X.[112] Finally, as previously highlighted, according to a senior Indian miliatary intelligence officer, 'we're [Indians] fascinated by the Pashtuns but they have not done anything for us. When they have a choice to make between Pakistan and India then they may not side with us'.[113]

NSA M. K. Narayanan was arguably the most influential, and nuanced, partisan. He adjusted to the realities of post-2001 Afghanistan unlike Katju, R, and to a limited extent X. Instead of limiting support to Karzai, Narayanan invested heavily in the former and the fervently anti-Pakistan intelligence chief from Panjsher, Amrullah Saleh, with whom Narayanan shared an excellent rapport (and whom he rated to be among the top three or four intelligence chiefs in the world).[114] In 2008, after the bombing of the Indian embassy complex in Kabul, for instance, Narayanan reached out to Saleh to assess possibilities of jointly targeting militant infrastructure in Pakistan.[115] 'Talk-talk is better than fight-fight, but it hasn't worked. I think we need to pay [Pakistan] back in the same coin', he advocated (this line had support among many conciliators such as Menon, but who decided not to make public proclamations about their intent).[116] The statement was not bereft of context. Saleh, under Karzai's watch, had developed links with a host of anti-Pakistan elements operating across the Durand Line, including Baloch separatists. As a later section in this book details,